

Samsung Display ends deal

Samsung Display has reportedly decided to end its deal with Apple, stopping the supply of LCD panels to its longtime partner



Updated LinkedIn BlackBerry app

LinkedIn finally updated its app available on BlackBerry devices, making it compatible with BB6 and BB7, and adding several new features

personality most matches yours, based on the data generated by your answers. Just a small example of the many possibilities that open up by analysing Big Data.

Analysing crime report patterns to help predict crimes before they happen, using call frequency analysis to understand consumer behaviour and give them better services – the potential for the use of Big Data are endless. If we end up eventually living in a world that runs primarily on the information generated by the analysis of Big Data, it will hopefully bring us closer as a race, as we learn more about the people around us and across the world, and use that information to bridge the gaps between us and overcome our differences.

Big is not necessarily always better

Big Data is generated through many methods, out of which one of the most common is “data mining”. What it essentially means is that once you have massive amounts of information, you can mine that information and discover new patterns and relationships that you’re not aware of normally, because you cannot compute at that level on an average basis. This has given rise to the term “macro-scope” – like a telescope or a microscope – which means looking at data to discover new patterns that were never known/seen before. And that may pose a problem.

OUR BIG DATA

- 80 per cent of all humans own a mobile phone of some sort. Out of 5 billion mobiles, 1 billion are smartphones. (In Singapore, 54 per cent of citizens are smartphone users.)
- 60 per cent of all humans (5.4 billion people) are active texters. In 2010, 193,000 text messages were sent every second.
- 50 per cent of 5-year-old kids in the U.S. are given access to a smartphone.
- 10 per cent of all photos ever taken were taken in 2011.

When companies gather information about consumers, they collect a wide variety of it, ranging from personal information to buying patterns to even eating habits and medical problems.

Correlating this data lets them establish new patterns and find new information, such as deducing that a customer is pregnant (sometimes before family and friends know) based on her purchases and patterns in her behaviour (this actually happened in the United States where well-known retail chain Target identified pregnant customers by the above method and then sold them baby products). Creepy enough? It can get worse.

Big Data incentivises collection and longer safekeeping of data, leading to massive storage banks of potentially private and confidential data that consumers might be uncomfortable sharing otherwise. Using this data to draw conclusions about the consumers would violate their sense of privacy. And this gives companies greater incentive to reveal minimal amount of the data they might actually be generating and storing on you.

Use of data mining by law enforcement is another matter altogether. Labelling someone as a potential criminal before they have done anything, based on data generated from behaviour patterns, turns the entire concept of human rights and justice on its head. One can no longer claim innocence till proven guilty, as your guilt would be established even before the crime on the basis of what you’ve been doing over the past months. Try wrapping your head around that concept.

Big Data also has the potential to tilt the scales in the favour of big organizations with access to it, and away from individuals and common people who might not have the resources needed to gain access to Big Data, let alone analyze it. Economically speaking, it can allow big companies to gain unfair advantages over smaller competitors who do not have access to the same kind of information. It also holds a lot of potential for manipulation and misuse of data – if a store knows exactly how much I can afford to spend on a product, how much I know about

competitive prices in the marketplace, and how badly I need/want the product, it can use this information to its advantage and derive the maximum possible profit from me. Literally, milk me for all I’m worth.

Big Data can also be a divisive catalyst in most socio-economic scenarios. By amplifying existing advantages and disadvantages, Big Data has the potential to further widen the gap between the haves and the have-nots. Those who are savvy and well-educated, with ‘positive’ Big Data, are likelier to get better treatment from governments as well as private



Shwetak Patel's efforts prove how useful Big Data can be to everyday people

companies, as compared to those who are poor, ‘underprivileged’, and with some form of negative Big Data, like a criminal record for petty theft. The latter will be identified easily, and might face prejudices, thereby restricting their chances of rehabilitation into society, and further increasing stratification in society.

Summing it up...

As is evident, Big Data has enormous potential for improvement our understanding of us as an evolving species, and predicting future trends with increasing accuracy. But, there are a lot of problems – ethical and otherwise – embedded in the process of using Big Data, that need to be properly addressed before it is adopted wholeheartedly. Until we can manage to find the right balance between these two sides, a wary and controlled approach is perhaps the best way to adopt for the world of wonders that Big Data can unlock for us. 